

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 974

By Jones J

A RESOLUTION to honor Cheryl McKissack Daniel and the
McKissack family, trailblazers of Black history.

WHEREAS, it is our privilege to recognize those historic families of this State who have exhibited exceptional character, ability, and commitment, achieving the pinnacle of success while shaping the future and inspiring others to greatness; and

WHEREAS, one such enduring family is the McKissack family, who began a business and legacy in Tennessee in the mid-1800s that now sees its current generations working at the peak of its industry; and

WHEREAS, McKissack & McKissack holds the distinction of being the oldest minority- and woman-owned professional design and construction firm in the nation; it was founded in 1905 by Moses McKissack III and Calvin L. McKissack, grandsons of Moses McKissack, who was captured in his native West Africa and enslaved on American shores by a North Carolina plantation owner; and

WHEREAS, Moses McKissack was a skilled craftsman who made bricks; his son, Moses McKissack II, was a carpenter and master builder who resided in Spring Hill, Tennessee, and moved to Pulaski after emancipation, starting his business in that town, which happened to also be the birthplace of the Ku Klux Klan; and

WHEREAS, despite rampant discrimination, the McKissacks continued to grow their business, serving Black communities through building projects for churches and historically Black colleges; and

WHEREAS, the McKissack family's fingerprints have been left across the United States, spanning from Reconstruction to contemporary times, through projects such as the Morris Memorial Building, Capers C.M.E. Church, and Philadelphia's Lincoln Financial Field; and

WHEREAS, current CEO and President of McKissack & McKissack Cheryl McKissack Daniel is a Nashville native and the daughter of architect William DeBerry and teacher Leatrice Buchanan McKissack; she is the fifth generation of the McKissack family to head the family enterprise; and

WHEREAS, Mrs. McKissack Daniel leads the firm with more than thirty years of experience in all phases of the construction industry and serves as Principal-in-Charge and Project Executive on numerous high-profile projects, including major work in the commercial, healthcare, education, and transportation sectors, and is actively involved in project oversight and management, ensuring that diversity is implemented during each phase of a project or program; and

WHEREAS, under Mrs. McKissack Daniel's leadership, the company has grown into one of the nation's leading design and construction management firms, overseeing more than \$50 billion in projects, including New York's JFK Airport Terminal One, the Oculus at Ground Zero, and the Barclays Center in Brooklyn; and

WHEREAS, Mrs. McKissack Daniel recently published the riveting story of the McKissack family, *The Black Family Who Built America: The McKissacks, Two Centuries of Daring Pioneers* (2025), to wide acclaim; and

WHEREAS, Cheryl McKissack Daniel's book celebrates the enduring themes of resilience, representation, and legacy—values that have guided the McKissack family for over 120 years; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor Cheryl McKissack Daniel and the trailblazing McKissack family for their many contributions to history and culture throughout this State and nation, and

congratulate Mrs. McKissack Daniel on the publication of *The Black Family Who Built America: The McKissacks, Two Centuries of Daring Pioneers*.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.